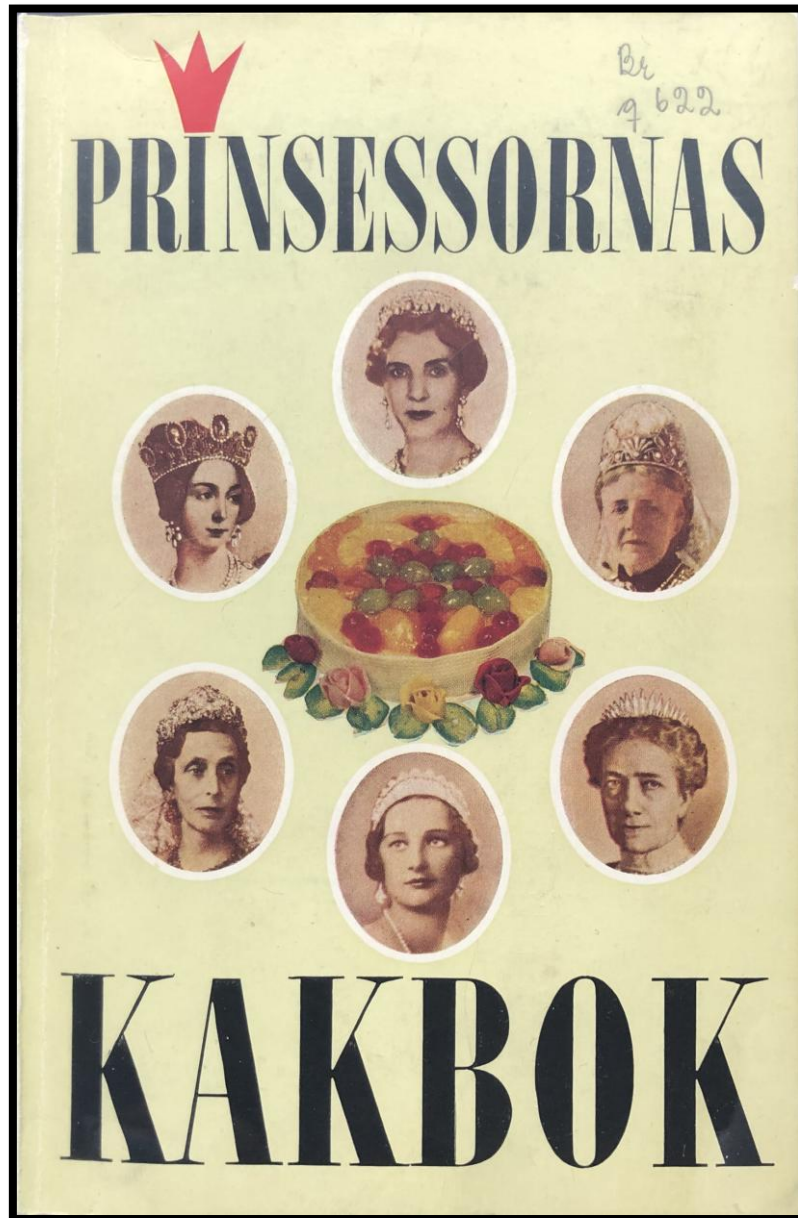


# “PRINSESSORNAS KAKBOK”

Digitalisering för bevarande och tillgänglighet

VT2026



Högskolan i Borås

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# 1. Introduction

## 1.1. About the *Husmodern*

Between 1917 and 1988, Swedish families were the primary audience for *Husmodern* (The Housewife), a highly successful weekly magazine. Initially launched by home economics expert Thora Holm-Lundberg and journalist Elsa Nyblom, the publication was originally designed to help women navigate the domestic challenges and household management issues brought on by World War I (Bonniers Familjestiftelse, n.d.).

In 1920, the Åhlén & Åkerlund publishing company acquired the magazine. Under this new ownership, its scope broadened significantly. It began offering comprehensive advice and fostering discussions on all aspects of domestic life, from raising children to managing family finances (Bonniers Familjestiftelse, n.d.)

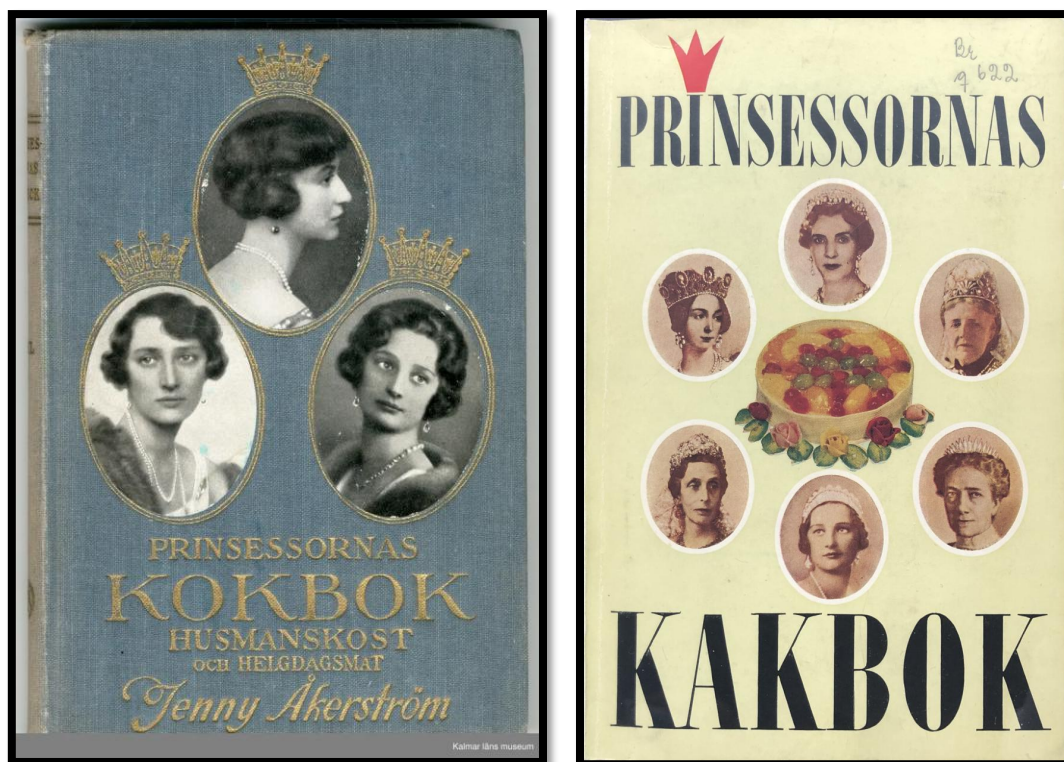
As the decades passed, particularly beginning in the 1960s, the publication's editorial direction shifted. It gradually transitioned into a more conventional women's lifestyle magazine, increasingly dedicating its pages to celebrity news and gossip. Regardless of these changes, *Husmodern* enjoyed a long reign as one of Sweden's most beloved weeklies, ultimately hitting its peak circulation of roughly 290,000 copies per week around 1970 (Hedman, 2021, p. 29).

## 1.2. About the chosen material

*Prinsessornas Kakkbok* (Princesses' cake book) seems to be an extra add to the magazine *Husmodern*, it might have been sold with the magazine or separately, as it has its own price on the backside. It was published in 1960 when the magazine's direction changed to a more conventional one. The recipes were chosen from the *Prinsessornas Kokbok* (The Princesses' Cookbook).

First published in 1929, *Prinsessornas kokbok* (The Princesses' Cookbook) by Jenny Åkerström-Söderström stands as a definitive classic within Swedish culinary literature. During the first half of the twentieth century, Åkerström operated a prestigious domestic science school for young women in Stockholm. Among her elite pupils were Princesses Margaretha, Märtha, and Astrid, the daughters of Prince Carl and Princess Ingeborg. Åkerström dedicated the cookbook to these royal students, and the guide became an absolute household staple, seeing numerous updated editions throughout the 1930s, 1940s, and 1950s (Kokböckerna, n.d.).

The book's most famous legacy centres on a recipe originally titled simply *Green Cake*, which the princesses were said to have been exceptionally fond of. Because of their royal endorsement, this dessert eventually became known as the iconic *prinsesstårta*, or princess cake, which remains a cornerstone of Swedish baking today (Hansson, 2016). To add a touch of royal glamour to the pages, Åkerström shared the princesses' specific opinions on the various dishes, giving everyday home cooks a delightful glimpse into the culinary preferences of royalty.



Source of the picture illustrating *Prinsessornas Kokbok*: <https://digitaltmuseum.se/021028547498/bok>

The original *Prinsessornas Kokbok* was a series of four books. The picture above on the left side shows a book published in 1931. Portrait photographs on the front cover include Princess Margaretha of Denmark, Crown Princess Märtha of Norway and Crown Princess Astrid of Belgium (Sörmlands Museum, 2025). The *Prinsessornas Kakbok* that was partially digitalised by us includes pictures of (from left to right, top to bottom):

1. Josephine of Leuchtenberg, Queen of Sweden and Norway
2. Ingrid of Sweden, Queen of Denmark
3. Sophia of Nassau, Queen of Sweden and Norway
4. Princess Louise of Battenberg, Queen of Sweden
5. Princess Astrid of Sweden, Queen of the Belgians
6. Victoria of Baden, Queen of Sweden.

It is quite interesting why the publisher chose those six women and not only the three from the original publication. However, there is no information about the reason behind it in the book.

### 1.3. About KvinnSam

KvinnSam stands as an unparalleled asset in Sweden, serving as the country's dedicated national library for gender research and a cornerstone of the University of Gothenburg's research infrastructure since 2018. Functioning as an integral part of the university's library system, it is physically located within the Library of Humanities.

The institution's primary responsibilities include the systematic tracking and indexing of literature related to gender studies, alongside the collection and organization of historical archives concerning women's history. Furthermore, KvinnSam provides specialized reference services and plays a proactive role in supporting the development of research initiatives that utilize its extensive collections and staff expertise.

Under the current leadership of Acting Director Christa Shusko and Assistant Director AnnaLena Bergquist, the organization continues to facilitate and coordinate high-level academic inquiry into gender-related fields (KvinnSam, n.d.).

#### **1.4. Relevance for the cultural heritage preservation**

Scholars Prescott and Hughes (2018) point out that transferring documents into digital formats unlocks distinctive analytical methodologies for researchers. In the context of a twentieth-century book, this prompts an exploration into how digital interfaces can be intentionally designed to optimize user engagement and comprehension. The authors further advocate for a more deliberate, measured approach to archiving—one that prioritizes profound textual understanding over mere speed and challenges investigators to reflect more critically on their source materials. Embracing this philosophy, the current initiative involving *Prinseessornas kakbok* explores how modern reproduction tools can best safeguard and democratize access to historical artifacts while evaluating the best ways to represent a text digitally.

Deciding which historical fragments merit conservation is an intrinsically biased process driven by evolving societal values, forcing us to confront difficult questions about cultural ownership and historical exclusion. The survival of this specific collection relies entirely on the existence of KvinnSam in Gothenburg, an institution born from a dedicated interest in women's history. As Holm (1993) observes, this sphere of research has historically been relegated to the periphery.

This endeavour also intersects with the concept of public interest, a theme explored by Cowick (2018), who implicitly challenges the conventional notion of market demand by suggesting that audiences cannot seek out archives they do not know exist. KvinnSam's dual mission to protect and broadcast these records satisfies a broader social imperative to re-center women in historical discourses. While the immediate beneficiaries of this digital repository are may be academic researchers, the project ultimately enriches the general public. This synergy reflects insights highlighted by Björk (2015), which demonstrate how digital and physical mediums mutually enhance one another, since electronic formats introduce advanced search functionalities that breathe new utility into traditional collections. Consequently, the transition to a digital medium yields an undeniable victory for historical accessibility.

## 2. Method

### 2.1. The selection process

As group we decided to contact KvinnSam, as we are interested in the topic of women's visibility in the history. The group send an email to Rachel Pierce, whose contact information was provided by the lecturer in charge of the Digitalisation course. Rachel Pierce works as a Research Coordinator at KvinnSam, and we maintained contact with her during the project.

The selection process involved stating our interest in working with their collection, and after the initial contact, expressing our ideas about potential materials to work with. Rachel shared links to possible materials for digitization, both from the archive collection and the special library, and informed us about KvinnSam's current priorities for digitalisation. The next step was to make a selection of options so that Rachel could show us the physical materials during our in-person appointment at the library, where she would also explain the rules for working with their materials, principles by which the library operates, the reservation process, and different procedures that may be important for the project.

*Husmodern* was one of the titles among the suggested materials, and also on the list of priorities to be digitalised in the future. The material comprised in the *Husmodern* collection has particularly caught our attention as it was a magazine for women edited initially only by women. We found it as innovative for this time period, and also as demonstrating the changing role of women in the society. It seemed for us to be an important development in the Swedish publishing landscape. As a group, we then went through the available materials published by *Husmodern* and ultimately chose *Prinsessornas Kakkbok*. The whole recipe book is 72 pages long and we decided to make a sample out of it, including both recipes with and without pictures, some of them longer and shorter ones as well.

Access to the material is by reservation only and the reserved material is obtained in the special reading room. This material does not belong to the archive, but rather to the special materials' collection. Therefore, it gave us some degree of freedom when accessing the material, since we did not have to depend on Rachel for reserving a specific location for taking photos, but rather made a reservation through the Library of the Humanities' website. The material we have chosen cannot be taken outside the library and must be handled with utmost care.

The selection process is something discussed by Cowick (2018, p. 11). We discussed the worth of the digitalised material and agreed that *Husmodern*, as a whole, demonstrates a shift in the role of women in society by assumint the responsibility for the entire editorial process. At the same time, we are fully aware that the material we have chosen to digitalise in order to create this exhibition represents our own interpretation of its significance, as is the case with all digitalisation projects (Björk, 2015, p. 40). Our project is small-scale and its purpose was to capture the essence of the digitalised object, thus, it is a critical digitalisation, not a mass digitalisation (Dahlström, 2023, pp. 474-475).

## **2.2. The legal aspects of the project**

The chosen material was published in 1960 and is, therefore, still protected by the copyright. We decided to publish it purely for the educational purposes and include a disclaimer stating that if any copyright holder requests its removal from the website, it will be immediately removed.

We have chosen to use Creative Commons to indicate the copyright of the digitalised material. As explained in Pedley (2007, p. 95), the Creative Commons provides licenses for creative materials and helps preserve copyright while also encouraging the use of the material by a broader audience. Creative Commons also offers various symbols for its different licenses, providing a quick overview of what is permitted with the work in question.

## **2.3. Image capturing and editing**

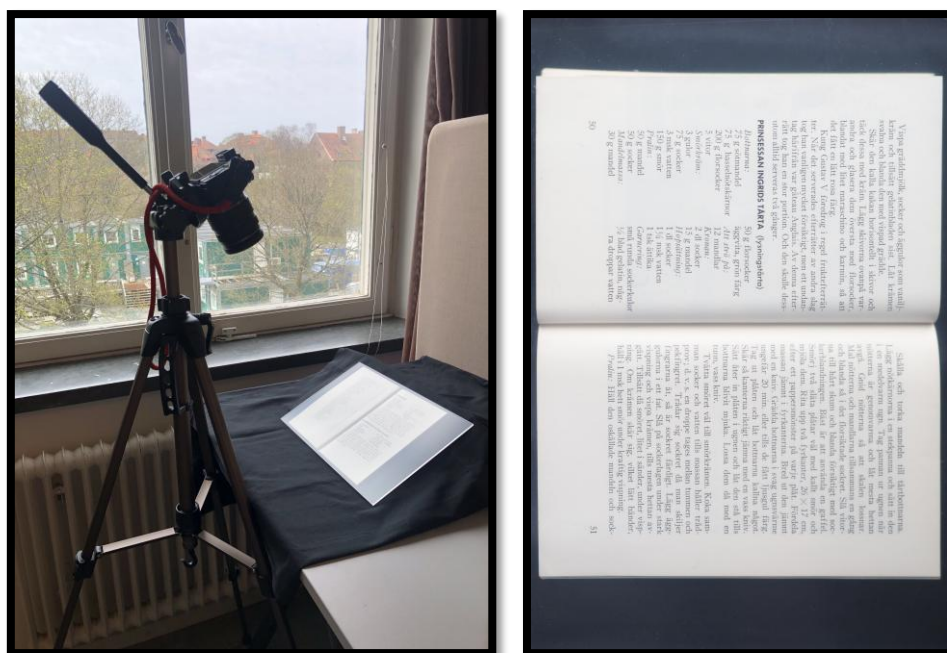
As a group, we decided to photograph the entire recipe book and then select the pages we felt were most suitable for the project. This decision was made because one of the team members lives in Linköping, so due to the logistical issues we could not all be present at the library on the chosen day and time for the purpose of the photoshoot.

For taking the images, we decided to use the book-scanner in the special reading room. We scanned all sides in both TIFF and PDF formats. Then, we took photos with an Olympus camera and an iPhone. However, the images were not of an adequate quality. The scanned images were excessively white, and the colours did not match the original. The result did not correspond to what we wanted to show - the essence of the original recipe book – elements such as the paper colour and the colours in the images, which should be as close to the original as possible (Cowick, 2018, p. 47).

Regarding the TIFF images, we made a mistake in the process, as we only saved two. The images taken with both, the camera and the iPhone, had severe distortion in the text and image when exported to the computer, which could not be removed even after adjusting them in Affinity. Therefore, the decision was made to retake the photos. “Quality is a property of digital objects that needs attention...” (Ros (2007) cited by Conway (2014), p. 57).

Being very aware of the previous mistakes, we decided not to use the book-scanner and instead to focus on taking the photos with the camera and the iPhone. We added several elements to help in achieving the desired photo quality. We used a tripod and placed a black cloth over the surface, positioned the recipe book at an approximate 45-degrees angle, and used a piece of clear, antireflective acrylic to weigh it down and prevent distortion (Cowick, 2018, pp. 49-50).





The photographs above show the placement of one of the devices and how the object being photographed looked. After taking the pictures, we immediately exported the photographs to the computer to better evaluate the quality and details. This process allowed us to correct and re-take those of the photos that, for some reason, had not turned out well. The transparent, anti-reflective acrylic prevented unwanted reflections and helped to spread the natural light more evenly, without losing the original colour of the recipe book.

We have all the original photographs; however, the pictures that we selected and are presenting here have been cropped, according to the template we chose to use for the digital version of the recipe book (Cowick, 2018, p. 50).

## 2.4. Transcription of the text

For this project, we used a combination of automated tools and manual work to capture the text. We began by using the OCR (Optical Character Recognition) function in Google Docs to extract text from JPEG images. However, we did not just rely on what the computer produced. We treated that initial result as a rough draft and carefully read through everything ourselves, correcting any errors by hand. This helped us make sure that the text was correct.

One group member carried out the transcription of the book, and the text was later proofread by another member of the group. Although the book, published in 1960, features clear and consistent printing—which generally supports accurate OCR—we found that manual correction was still necessary. As Simon Tanner (2004) points out, human intervention, including careful proofreading and correction, is often required to produce a result that is suitable for publication (p.11).

Most of the minor issues we encountered were related to the words split across lines in the original layout, which can be difficult for OCR systems to interpret correctly. Aside from these



small errors, the text was generally accurate, largely due to the uniform quality of the printing. This process worked well, and the transcription was completed efficiently.

## 2.5. TEI

After we finished transcription and proofreading of *Prinsessornas kakbok*, the text was encoded into TEI format according to the standards of the Text Encoding Initiative Consortium (2025). TEI is an international standard used by libraries, museums, and researchers to represent texts accurately in digital form. The transparency of the TEI XML format makes it the preferred choice for long-term digital preservation, as recommended by the Deutsche Forschungsgemeinschaft (2013, p. 33).

During the encoding process, we chose to include all text found on the pages, as well as selected images. We took inspiration from last year's projects and studied how TEI encoding had been implemented there. We also used Wout Dillen's template as a reference and consulted TEI exercise materials to better understand the encoding process. The TEI encoding was carried out by one member of the group and later proofread by another member to ensure accuracy and consistency.

Our encoding was structured using the core elements of `<teiHeader>`, `<text>`, and `<body>`. In the `<teiHeader>`, we included comprehensive metadata relevant to the project, such as information about the physical material (including its dimensions of 19.2 cm x 12.5 cm, and paper support), the institutions involved (Högskolan i Borås), and the repository location at KvinnSam in Gothenburg. Furthermore, we established a clear licensing framework using a Creative Commons Attribution 4.0 International license to support the preservation and research goals of the project.

The `<body>` section of our file holds the actual text from the book pages. We used the `<pb>` tag and the `@facs` attribute to link each digital page directly to its original image. Since cookbooks have tricky layouts, we used the `<ab>` tag with `xml:space="preserve"` to keep the ingredient lists in their original two-column format—just like they appear in the "Victoria-kaka" recipe.

To meet the scientific objective of reproducing the original material as faithfully as possible (Deutsche Forschungsgemeinschaft (2013, p. 6), we focused on ensuring that the digital version closely reflects the 1960s publication. We are aware that when the document is digitalised future users will interact with it as if it was the actual object itself (Dillen, 2017, p. 398). Therefore, instead of updating the spelling or grammar, we kept everything in its original form to help future researchers see the text exactly as it was first published. We used `<lb/>` elements to show precisely where lines ended on the page and made sure not to change any punctuation or hyphens. Since the pictures are such a big part of the book, we used `<figure>` and `<figDesc>` tags for the crown icons and recipe illustrations, ensuring they were properly included in our XML file.

## 2.6. Metadata

Metadata extraction from the master images in TIFF format was performed using ExifTool, a command-line application specialized in reading, writing, and converting metadata embedded in digital files.

ExifTool allows access to various metadata schemas present in TIFF files, including EXIF, IPTC, XMP, and Dublin Core. To obtain a structured and reusable representation of this metadata, the -X option was used, which exports the information in RDF/XML format. XML was chosen as the serialization format due to its inherent characteristics: it is designed to be readable by both humans and machines, relatively easy to produce, and suitable for the automated processing of structured information. These properties have contributed to its widespread adoption in various metadata schemas and document interoperability (Drappert et al. 2016, p. 164).

This command processes the original TIFF file and redirects the standard output to a separate XML file containing the complete metadata of the digital objects.

The generated RDF/XML file includes technical and descriptive information such as image dimensions, resolution, creation and modification dates, authorship, and other XMP or Dublin Core elements present in the file header.

Subsequently, the relevant metadata was integrated into the TEI document using the element `<pb n="Cover" facs="../collection/img/TIFF/00_Cover.tiff" corresp="../collection/metadata/metadata00_Cover.xml"/>`, preserving the RDF/XML structure to ensure compatibility with the TEI schema.

This procedure allowed for the preservation of the master file's original technical metadata (Cowick, 2018, p. 20) and the integration of standardized descriptive information into the TEI environment, facilitating interoperability and long-term preservation of digital objects (Drappert et al., 2016, p. 161).

## 2.7. Publication and preservation

As a group, we worked with the platform GitHub where we published the complete version of our project. We created our repository inspired by the templates of Wout Dillen, university lecturer at Högskolan i Borås.

Regarding the appearance and navigation in our project, we were inspired by previous students' project works that were available for us through the Högskolan's platform Canvas.

For long-term preservation, the files are available on GitHub, as well as stored locally on our own hard drives. However, because of the legal nature of our project, it is possible that it will not be available on GitHub in the future, if any of the copyright holders require its removal.

### 3. Expenditure of time

We have documented the hours spent by all group members on various activities during the project. The table below illustrates the expenditure of time, divided into relevant categories.

| The activity                                                                                                                | Time (hours) |
|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------|
| Preparatory work (reading the relevant literature, learning to use GitHub, experimenting with different file formats, etc.) | 50           |
| Group meetings (via Zoom or WhatsApp)                                                                                       | 10           |
| Group discussions (via WhatsApp)                                                                                            | 30           |
| Contact with KvinnSam                                                                                                       | 25           |
| Choosing the material                                                                                                       | 10           |
| Research about the chosen material                                                                                          | 30           |
| Image capturing and editing                                                                                                 | 70           |
| Transcription of the text                                                                                                   | 20           |
| Working with TEI                                                                                                            | 65           |
| Working with metadata                                                                                                       | 30           |
| Working with XSLT and publishing the website                                                                                | 80           |
| Contact with the teacher for counseling                                                                                     | 15           |
| Proofreading                                                                                                                | 20           |
| Writing a rapport                                                                                                           | 60           |
| <b>Total number of hours</b>                                                                                                | <b>515</b>   |

The total number of hours spent for the project was about 515. Our material was accessible only at the library, but we excluded here time for our journeys as it differs between group members. It happened also that when we were at the library the staff could not find our material and we needed to wait around two hours until the book was found. Image capturing and editing took more time than we expected, and one of the reasons for it was that we needed to retake our photographs due to unsatisfying quality. The most time-consuming moment was working with XSLT and publishing the website in order to get the result we wanted.

### 4. Possible continuations of the project

The most obvious and possible continuation of the project would be the digitalisation of the whole *Prinsessornas Kabbok*, in collaboration with KvinnSam and Rachel Pierce. It would be,

then, possible to present all the recipes collected in the book or even to compare them with those in the original *Prinsessornas Kokbok*. However, the information given in the *Prinsessornas Kokbok* does not specify which edition of the original publication they are based on. Maybe, this data could be obtained via contact with the copyright's holder. Moreover, it seems interesting to find out whether *Prinsessornas Kokbok* was published and sold on its own (as it has a price tag on the back cover) or together with some number of the magazine *Husmodern*. As for now, this data is not available.

Knowing that *Husmodern* is one of the digitalisation priorities for KvinnSam, our project could contribute to much bigger project of digitalising all the assets in *Husmodern* collection that could make it accessible to the broader public. Even though we decided to make a sample of *Prinsessornas Kokbok* we photographed all the pages in the book and Rachel Pierce at KvinnSam has the access to all of them.

Furthermore, there is an ongoing research project about the handwritten recipes at the University of Gothenburg (more information available here: <https://www.gu.se/nyheter/forskning-om-handskrivna-recept-vacker-gensvar>) so it might be possible to connect both projects while presenting them to the public. The University's project highlights also the fact that food recipes are indeed an important part of the cultural heritage that should be preserved.

## 5. Critical analysis

While working with the project, the group needed to make some decisions that influenced the final shape of our assignment. To create the website, we were inspired by earlier projects and by the template provided by Wout Dillen, however, the XSLT was entirely made by one of the group members. By having our own XSLT, we could add functions like red colour while clicking on the page that makes it much easier for the user to navigate the page and to know on which of the sub-pages they are.

Somebody might ask why we decided to present our material in four different views of: transcription, text, gallery and reading view. From the very beginning, we wanted to show the nature of the digitalised material as well as give the project the educational value in showing different possibilities while presenting the material. The transcription side provides pictures and the transcribed text side by side what makes it possible for the user to see the original pages but also read the computer version of the text that may be easier to read. It makes it also possible to copy the transcribed text if somebody would be interested in it, while still preserving the original layout from the book. All the words that are not so common in modern Swedish are preserved as they are, and the same is true for different techniques described in the book. It gives a glimpse into the language used in the 1960s, the availability of the different products, and the skills that were expected of a housewife in order to prepare the recipes.

The text side provides smaller pictures and all the text on the pages with recipes and accentuates the text on the images with a different colour to enhance visibility. The gallery side provides

the possibility to zoom in and take a closer look on all of the photographed pages that makes it possible to examine not only the content of the pages, but also the condition of the paper and different small details. Then, the reading view provides an experience more similar to flipping the pages of an actual book, side by side, and does not require the user to scroll down the page, only click on one of the arrows, that makes reading more comfortable.

## 6. Conclusions

The project gave us an invaluable insight into the process of digitalising a cultural heritage material. It made us aware of different aspects that one might need to considerate and the problems that one might stumble upon. We hope that we managed to present *Prinsessornas Kakbok* in a way that is as close to the original as possible and give the user an experience close to reading the original publication. With this said, we are fully aware that it is not possible to fully recreate all of the properties of a printed book in a digital way. We hope to raise the interest in the role of a Swedish housewife, the changing role of women in the society, and in seeing culinary traditions as an important part of the national cultural heritage.

We would like to extend special thanks to Rachel Pierce and Wout Dillen for their guidance during this project.

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